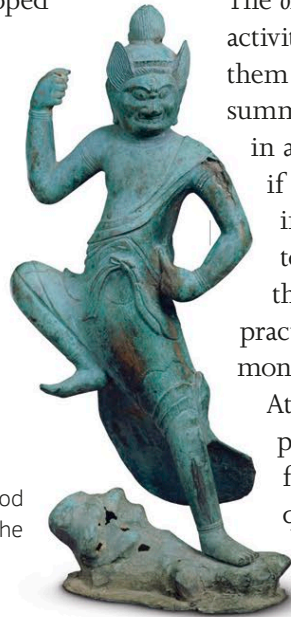


MINISTRY OF MAGIC

ancient Japanese magic

In Japan's traditional Shinto religion, almost everything—trees, rivers, mountains, and even buildings—was host to *kami*, resident spirits whose powers could be harnessed or anger appeased by specialists. The *kitsune-tsukai* (witches possessed by fox spirits) were a particularly powerful form of *kami*. They could change shape, become invisible, or even possess others. In the 5th and 6th centuries BCE, Buddhism, Daoism, and the Chinese systems of the Five Elements and yin-yang were introduced to Japan and merged with Shinto. In response to all these influences, and to ascertain the will of *kami*, the Japanese developed a complex system of divination.

Occult practitioners called the *onmyōji* performed divination rituals and read omens from the stars and unusual phenomena such as eclipses. They even carried out exorcisms by summoning a spirit to enter the victim's body and interrogate the possessing spirit to identify it. Then they could



► Buddhist mountain deity

This bronze statue shows Zaō Gongen, a god associated with remote mountains, where he was worshipped by hermits who practiced *jugondo* to acquire his physical power.

perform the correct ritual to expel the unwanted spirit. The *onmyōji* became court officials, and *onmyōdō* (their practice) became so accepted that there was even a Divination Bureau to appoint them. The practice of *monoimi*, the decision whether or not to accept visitors based on the *onmyōji*'s findings, and *henbai*, rituals to protect court members while traveling, continued until Emperor Meiji came to power in 1868 and banned them.

Witches, charms, and folk magic

The *onmyōji*'s repertoire also included activities close to sorcery. Many of them possessed *shikigami*, spirit familiars summoned as servants, who often appeared in animal form, and could be vengeful if the relevant ritual was performed incorrectly. *Onmyōji* employed charms to ward off evil called *ofuda*, often in the form of hanging paper strips. Some also practiced *jugondo*, which dealt with vanquishing monsters and healing diseases.

At this popular level of magic, the grand pronouncements of the *onmyōji* veered into folklore. People believed that a storm could be quelled by burning the pelt of a black dog, or cowardice cured by chewing the shavings of a tree that had been struck by lightning.



▲ Star and planet rituals

This drawing from a Japanese astrological text is of Doyō, the deity linked with Saturn and the last day of the week—which was associated with illness and arguments, and believed to be a bad day to get married.

ABE NO SEIMEI (921–1005)

Mainstream magic

The most famous *onmyōji*, Abe no Seimei specialized in analyzing odd events and performing exorcisms. The author of several works on fortune-telling, he gained favor at court by telling the sex of unborn noble babies and became head of the Divination Bureau, which his clan controlled until the 19th century. He acquired a name for his mystical powers, said to have come from his *kitsune-tsukai* mother, a status he confirmed in an epic series of magical duels with his rival Doman Ashiya. In one episode, Doman hid 15 oranges in a box and challenged Abe to divine what was in it. Abe transformed the oranges in the box into rats and guessed their number correctly.

